

Statement of Academic Intent

Israel Olayemi Anjorin | MBA with Advanced Studies in Management | Lakehead University

Who I Am and Where I Come From

My name is Israel Anjorin. I grew up in Lagos, Nigeria, built a career in finance and accounting, led teams through Rotary International, started a small photography business, and in 2022 moved to the United States to be with my wife. None of that was a straight line, and I would not have it any other way.

I started my career at FedEx REDSTAR EXPRESS, where I spent nearly six years working across three different finance roles. I came in as a Revenue Analyst, moved up to Payable Analyst, and eventually became a Management Accountant overseeing tax liabilities, accruals, monthly financial reporting, and accounts reconciliation for a multinational logistics operation. That experience gave me a real understanding of what it means to manage financial systems under pressure, across borders, and with accountability to people beyond yourself.

Outside of work, I served with Rotary International for seven years, eventually becoming Club President, Club Treasurer, and District Administrator for District 9110 in Lagos. We delivered eye care to over 70 elders, provided food packages to more than 200 widows, and ran vocational programs for small business owners who needed more than just encouragement. I also founded Esprit Photography, a small business where I learned, sometimes the hard way, what it takes to build something from nothing, manage clients, and stay creative under financial pressure.

When I arrived in the United States, I could not work immediately due to immigration limitations, so I volunteered. Over 1,300 hours between The Giving Plate and Furnish Hope, feeding families and moving furniture for people starting over. It was humbling and grounding in the best way. After that, I enrolled at Central Oregon Community College, earned my Associate of Applied Science in Accounting with a 3.83 GPA, and completed internships at Chris Mahr & Associates and Mary Allen Consulting, where I got hands-on experience with U.S. tax systems, QuickBooks, payroll, and multi-state compliance.

I am currently completed the first year of a dual MBA and MS in Data Science program at Willamette University in Salem, Oregon, one of only a few programs in the country that combines both degrees. My grades across both semesters have been strong, and more importantly, I have learned how to think differently about business problems by pairing financial instincts with data-driven analysis.

Why I Am Applying to Lakehead

I am applying to Lakehead University because my circumstances have changed and Canada has become the right next step for my family and my future. My wife and I are navigating a complex immigration situation in the United States, and Canada offers a path forward that the U.S. currently does not. That is honest, and I think honesty matters here.

But beyond the immigration reality, Lakehead genuinely appeals to me. The MBA with Advanced Studies in Management is exactly the kind of program I need at this stage of my career.

I am not a fresh graduate looking for my first taste of business. I am a working professional with real scars and real wins, who wants to deepen my knowledge of management, strategy, and leadership in a setting that takes those lived experiences seriously. The career-focused curriculum, the case-based learning, and the emphasis on ethical business leadership all reflect values I already hold and want to sharpen.

Thunder Bay is also a place I am genuinely open to. I have lived in Lagos, I have lived in Bend, Oregon. I know how to build community wherever I am, and I intend to do exactly that.

Where I Am Going

My short-term goal is to work in financial management or business consulting in Canada, ideally with organizations that care about both their bottom line and their communities. My long-term goal is to build a consulting practice that helps small businesses and nonprofits make better financial decisions, particularly organizations led by immigrants or underserved communities who have the drive but not always the tools.

The dual background I bring, accounting depth combined with data science training, puts me in a position to do something that many consultants cannot: translate complex financial and operational data into decisions that make sense to the people running the organization. That is the kind of advisor I want to be.

Strengths and Areas for Growth

My strengths are consistency, adaptability, and the ability to earn trust across very different environments. Whether I was reconciling accounts at FedEx Lagos, volunteering at a food pantry in Bend, or presenting financial analysis in an MBA classroom in Salem, I have always shown up prepared and accountable.

I will be transparent about one area of my academic record: my undergraduate GPA from Lagos State Polytechnic does not reflect where I am today. The courses were challenging, the environment was difficult, and I was younger. What I can point to instead is what I have done since, a 3.83 at COCC, strong performance at Willamette, six years of professional growth, and a consistent track record of taking on more responsibility, not less. I am not the same student I was in 2012. The record since then shows that clearly.

I am also still developing my quantitative and data analysis skills, which is exactly why I enrolled in the MS Data Science program at Willamette alongside my MBA. I do not shy away from the areas where I have room to grow. I go looking for them.

I am ready for Lakehead. I bring experience, perspective, and the kind of work ethic that does not need to be manufactured. I hope to contribute to this program as much as I gain from it.